

Extremistan-style variability, hence predators will necessarily go through periods of feast and famine. That's us, humans—we had to have been designed to experience extreme hunger and extreme abundance. So our food intake had to have been fractal. Not a single one of those promoting the “three meals a day,” “eat in moderation” idea has tested it empirically to see whether it is healthier than intermittent fasts followed by large feasts.[‡]

But Near Eastern religions (Judaism, Islam, and Orthodox Christianity) knew it, of course—just as they knew the need for debt avoidance—and so they had fast days.

I also knew that the size of stones and trees was, up to a point, fractal (I even wrote about that in [Chapter 16](#)). Our ancestors mostly had to face very light stones to lift, mild stressors; once or twice a decade, they encountered the need to lift a huge stone. So where on earth does this idea of “steady” exercise come from? Nobody in the Pleistocene jogged for forty-two minutes three days a week, lifted weights every Tuesday and Friday with a bullying (but otherwise nice) personal trainer, and played tennis at eleven on Saturday mornings. Not hunters. We swung between extremes: we sprinted when chased or when chasing (once in a while in an extremely exerting way), and walked about aimlessly the rest of the time. Marathon running is a modern abomination (particularly when done without emotional stimuli).

This is another application of the barbell strategy: plenty of idleness, some high intensity. The data shows that long, very long walks, combined with high-intensity exercise outperform just running.

I am not talking about “brisk walks” of the type you read about in the Health section of *The New York Times*. I mean walking without making any effort.

What's more, consider the negative correlation between caloric expenditure and intake: we hunted in response to hunger; we did not eat breakfast to hunt, hunting accentuated our energy deficits.

If you deprive an organism of stressors, you affect its epigenetics and gene expression—some genes are up-regulated (or down-regulated) by contact with the environment. A person who does not face stressors will not survive should he encounter them. Just consider what happens to someone's strength after he spends a year in bed, or someone who grows up in a sterile environment and then one day takes the Tokyo subway, where riders are squeezed like sardines.

Why am I using evolutionary arguments? Not because of the optimality of evolution, but entirely for epistemological reasons, how we